



THE MODI METHOD

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■ By Uday Mahurkar

The psephologists have turned apologists; a number of political pundits were eating humble pie instead of Christmas pudding. While Narendra Damodardas Modi laughs all the way to the vote bank—and possibly beyond—it is a political catastrophe for the Congress. No other election in recent years has aroused such extreme emotion or had so much at stake. It was, in many ways, a remarkable victory, but in the charged atmosphere and heightened rhetoric, one aspect has remained largely hidden: the electoral strategy that went beyond development and Hindutva. Behind that surcharged oratory is a carefully calibrated electoral campaign that covered all the bases, some overtly, but many that were obscured by the din of battle. An analysis of the victory, its implications and the strategy that helped him combat anti-incumbency, become chief minister for the third time in succession and also be talked of as a future prime minister.

THE VICTORY MARCH

One reason why many commentators and veterans of Indian elections got it so wrong was because of the odds stacked against a repeat win for Modi. If some of his partymen and ideological fraternity were baying for his blood and using the caste card to discredit him, a large section of Government employees were keen to see him go, thanks to his tight-fisted governance.

There was also the anti-incumbency factor which has destroyed many a political career, and the so-

called 'liberal' press, which tended to view Modi through the prism of the horrific genocide of 2002. In the end, his twin mantras of development and Hindutva based on an anti-terror platform proved too potent a weapon and the reverberations were felt outside Gujarat, causing as much consternation in the Congress and UPA as in the leadership of his own party—the question of whether the Modi effect would threaten power circles in Delhi or remain confined to Gujarat gathered momentum and meaning.

For Modi, the victory could not have been



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